

WE TAKE NATURE'S SERVICES FOR GRANTED BECAUSE WE DON'T PAY FOR THEM

A HOLISTIC VIEW OF EARTH

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Eugene Odum (1913–2002)

BEFORE

1905 In *Research Methods in Ecology*, American botanist Frederic Clements writes about plant communities and how they change over time.

1935 Arthur Tansley, a British botanist, proposes the term "ecosystem" to describe a community of plants, animals, soil minerals, water, and air.

AFTER

1954 Eugene and Howard Odum's study of the coral Eniwetok Atoll in the Pacific Ocean applies the principles of holistic ecology.

1974 British environmentalist James Lovelock and American biologist Lynn Margulis first publish their Gaia hypothesis. It states that Earth is a self-regulating system that maintains the conditions necessary for life on our planet.

The American ecologist Eugene Odum was not the first scientist to write about ecology, but in the 1950s he proposed that it deserved to be a discipline in its own right. Until then, ecology was viewed as a relatively insignificant subdivision of the biological sciences—the poor relation of